

Irene Farah

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EDUCATION

- Ph.D. **City & Regional Planning**, University of California, Berkeley, 2019–2024
Dissertation: *The Scramble for the City: Street Vending, Politics, and the Governance of Public Space in Mexico City and San Francisco*
- M.A. **Social Sciences**, University of Chicago, 2016–2017
Thesis: *A Geospatial Analysis of Mexico's Distal Effects on Food Insecurity*
- B.A. **Political Science**, Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, 2009–2013
Thesis: *Social Mobility of Women in Technical Schools in Mexico*

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

- 2025– Assistant Professor, Department of **Urban and Regional Planning**, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (UIUC)
- 2024–25 Illinois Distinguished Postdoctoral Research Associate, Department of **Urban and Regional Planning**, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign (UIUC)

ADDITIONAL RESEARCH AFFILIATIONS

- 2026– Assistant Professor, **National Center for Supercomputing Applications (NCSA)**, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign
- 2026– Affiliate, **Center for Latin American Studies**, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign
- 2026– Affiliate, **Social and Behavioral Sciences Institute**, University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign
- 2023–24 Visiting Research Associate, **Center for Demographic, Urban, and Environmental Studies**, Colegio de México (COLMEX)

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

- 2026 **Farah, I.**, Kelling, C., Leng, X., Zhao, Y., “Building a Longitudinal Geospatial Dataset of Micro-businesses in Mexico City.” In: *Environment and Planning B: Urban Analytics and City Science* (2026), pp. 1–19. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/23998083261460258>
- 2026 **Farah, I.** “The Legitimacy Trap: Street Vending Heterogeneity and Selective Enforcement in San Francisco.” In: *International Journal of Urban and Regional Research* (2026), pp. 1–23. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/1468-2427.70052>

- 2025 Credit, K., **Farah, I.**, Talen, E., Anselin, L., Ghomrawi, H., “The Walkable Accessibility Score (WAS): A spatially granular open-source measure of walkability for the continental US from 1997 to 2019.” In: *Environment and Planning B: Urban Analytics and City Science* (2025), pp. 1–18. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/23998083251377116>
- 2025 **Farah, I.**, Devlin, R. T., Hartmann, C., Harvey, J., Hegel, C., “The Governance of Informal Street Work in San Francisco and New York City.” In: *Nature Cities* 2 (10 2025), pp. 918–923. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s44284-025-00321-y>
- 2025 Domínguez-Barreto, A. P., **Farah, I.**, López-Olmedo, N., Pérez-Ferrer, C., Ramírez, Y., Langellier, B. A., Colchero, M., Rivera, J. A., Barrientos-Gutierrez, T., Stern, D., “Changes in the healthfulness of food and beverage purchases from 2006 to 2022 by outlet type in Mexico.” In: *BMC Medicine* (2025), pp. 1–23. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1186/s12916-025-04036-8>
- 2023 Ju, Y., Dronova, I., Rodríguez, D., Bakhtsiyarava, M., **Farah, I.**, “Recent Greening May Curb Urban Warming in Latin American Cities of Better Economic Conditions.” In: *Landscape and Urban Planning* 240 (2023), pp. 1–11. DOI: 10.1016/j.landurbplan.2023.104896
- 2023 Domínguez-Barreto, A. P., **Farah, I.**, López-Olmedo, N., Pérez-Ferrer, C., Ramírez, Y., Barrientos-Gutierrez, T., Stern, D., “Trends in Food and Beverage Purchases in Informal and Formal Outlets in Mexico: ENIGH 1994-2020.” In: *Frontiers in Public Health* 11 (2023), pp. 1–12. DOI: 10.3389/fpubh.2023.1151916
- 2022 **Farah, I.**, Stern, D., Ramírez, Y., López-Olmedo, N., Pérez-Ferrer, C., Langellier, B., Colchero, M. A., Barrientos-Gutierrez, T., “Food and beverage purchases at formal and informal outlets in Mexico.” In: *Public Health Nutrition* 26 (5 2022), pp. 1034–1043. DOI: 10.1017/S1368980022002324

Under Review

- 2026 Alonso Ferreira, M., **Farah, I.**, “How Cities Shape Bureaucracies: Rethinking Public Administration from Mexico City and São Paulo.” In: (under review)
- 2026 **Farah, I.** “Street Vending Bureaucrats as Brokers: Public Administration and the Politics of Public Space in Mexico City.” In: (under review)
- 2026 **Farah, I.** “Leveraging Panethnicity: Street Vending Governance and the Politics of the Latino Identity in San Francisco.” In: (under review)
- 2026 **Farah, I.** “Mercado Cananea: resistencia, autogestión y conflicto en la Ciudad de México.” In: *Mercados públicos, tianguis y comercio informal en América Latina*. Ed. by Ma. Susana Rosales and Verónica Crossa. Mexico City, Mexico: CEDUA, Colegio de México, 2026. Chap. (in press)

Book Chapters

- 2026 **Farah, I.** “The Informal Economy and Urban Design.” In: *The Routledge Handbook of Urban Design Practice*. Ed. by Molly O’Neill Robinson, Michael Angelo Larice, Allen Penniman, and Amanda Haycox. London: Routledge, 2026. Chap. 10.10, pp. 861–868. ISBN: 978-100-30-1365-5
- 2025 **Farah, I.** “La coexistencia de la planeación urbana con el comercio popular en la Ciudad de México.” In: *Retos de la agenda urbana en México*. Ed. by Sussy Keosseyian. Mexico City, Mexico: Bonilla Artiga Editores, 2025, pp. 97–128. ISBN: 978-968-97-2807-8

- 2025 Hayden, T. B., **Farah, I.**, “Urban Governance and the Regulation of Street Food Vending In Latin America.” In: *Urban Food Systems in Latin America: Territories, Mobilities and Governance*. Ed. by Tiana Bakić Hayden and Joaquín Pérez Martín. London: Routledge, 2025. Chap. 1, pp. 1–17
- 2023 Anselin, L., **Farah, I.**, “The Life and Death of Retail: Insights from Firm Demography.” In: *Streetlife: The Future of Urban Retail*. Ed. by Emily Talen and Conrad Kickert. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2023. Chap. 1, pp. 27–46
- 2023 Credit, K., **Farah, I.**, Anselin, L., “The Ups and Downs of Retail, 2000 – 2015.” In: *Streetlife: The Future of Urban Retail*. Ed. by Emily Talen and Conrad Kickert. Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2023. Chap. 2, pp. 47–74

Book Reviews and Miscellanea

- 2021 **Farah, I.** Rev. of *Forbearance as Redistribution: The Politics of Informal Welfare in Latin America*, by Alisha Holland. In: *Urban Studies* 59.2 (2021), pp. 469–471. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1177/004209802111058331>
- 2019 **Farah, I.**, Koschinsky, J., Noel, L., *Computing Travel Times and Spatial Access Metrics at Scale*. Documentation for Python package spatial_access 1.0.0. Center for Spatial Data Science at University Chicago. July 2019

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- 2021–22 Graduate Student Fellow, **Berkeley Food Institute**, UC Berkeley
- 2019–20 Graduate Researcher, **Institute of Urban and Regional Development**, UC Berkeley
- 2016–19 Research Associate, **Center for Spatial Data Science**, University of Chicago
- 2014–15 Research Advisor, **National Council for the Evaluation of Social Development Policy (CONEVAL)**, Mexico City

TEACHING

University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign

- 2026 Research Design and Methods (doctoral seminar)
- 2026 Introduction to Urban Data Science (undergraduate)
- 2025–26 Cities: Planning & Urban Life (undergraduate)

University of California, Berkeley

- 2022 Planning Methods Gateway: Part I (graduate), Graduate Student Instructor
- 2022 Maps as Social Justice Interventions, Instructor (co-created with Karen Chapple)
- 2021–22 R Geospatial and US Census, Workshops, D-Lab
- 2020, 22 Urban Informatics and Visualization (graduate), Graduate Student Instructor
- 2021 Introduction to City Planning, Graduate Student Instructor
- 2021 Introduction to Urban Data Analytics, Graduate Student Instructor

Colegio de México

2022–23 Introduction to Spatial Econometrics (graduate, in Spanish)

SELECTED PRESENTATIONS

* = Invited

- 2026 **Farah, I.** “Organizational Scale and the Coalition Dilemma: Street Market Associations Governing Public Space in Mexico City.” In: ***RC2I. On brokers and clienteles: new perspectives on urban politics, democracy and inequalities***. Vienna, Austria. 2026
- 2026 **Farah, I.** “How Cities Shape Bureaucracies: Rethinking Public Administration from Mexico City and São Paulo.” In: ***Urban Affairs Association***. Chicago, Illinois. 2026
- 2026 **Farah, I.** “How Cities Shape Bureaucracies: Rethinking Public Administration from Mexico City and São Paulo.” In: ***Midwest Political Science Association***. Chicago, Illinois. 2026
- 2026* **Farah, I.** “Associational Control and the Persistence of Subnational Authoritarianism: Street Vending Organizations in Mexico City.” In: ***Cities and Economic Democracy: Experiments in Comparative Perspective Symposium***. Urbana-Champaign, Illinois. 2026
- 2026 **Farah, I.** “Beyond the Stall: Using Location-Based Data to Reveal the Invisible Geography and Political Power of Street Vendors.” In: ***American Association of Geographers***. San Francisco, California. 2026
- 2025 **Farah, I.** “Nonprofits as Political Intermediaries: Street-Level Organizations in the Mission District of San Francisco.” In: ***Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning***. Minneapolis, Minnesota. 2025
- 2025* **Farah, I.** “Cities on the Edge: Urbanization, Sustainability, and the Future of Development in Mexico.” In: ***Today in International Politics: Speaker Series (TIPPS)***. Ohio State University. 2025
- 2024 **Farah, I.** “Street Vending Inspectors: Public Administration and the Politics of Public Space in Mexico City.” In: ***Urban Politics in the Global South***. Luskin Center for Innovation at UCLA, the APSA Urban, and Local Politics section. 2024
- 2024 **Farah, I.** “Multilevel Governance: The Regulation of Street Vendors in Mexico City.” In: ***Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning***. Seattle, Washington. 2024
- 2024 **Farah, I.** “The Scramble for the City: Beyond Clientelism: Street Vendor Bodies as a Form of Territorial and Political Power in Mexico City.” In: ***Latin American Studies Association***. Bogotá, Colombia. 2024
- 2024 **Farah, I.** “Street Vending Governance: Comparative Insights from Mexico City and San Francisco.” In: ***Urban Affairs Association***. New York City, New York. 2024
- 2023* **Farah, I.** “The Scramble for the City: Street Vending and the Politics of Public Space in Mexico City.” In: ***Urban and Regional Planning Program’s lunchtime seminar***. University of Michigan. 2023
- 2023 **Farah, I.** “Lightning talk: Street Vending Intermediation and Political Transformations in Mexico City: Exploring Urban Governance Dynamics.” In: ***Urban Politics in the Global South Workshop***. Luskin Center for Innovation at UCLA, the APSA Urban, and Local Politics section. 2023

- 2023 **Farah, I.** “Using Location-based Data to Understand the Governance Implications of Street Vendors’ Location in Mexico City.” In: *Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning*. Chicago, Illinois. 2023
- 2023 **Farah, I.** “Understanding the Travel Behavior of Street Vendors Using Location-Based Data and its Impact on the Regulation of Public Space in Mexico City.” In: *Movilidad urbana, sustentabilidad y justicia social en América Latina: saberes, prácticas y políticas*. Mexico City, Mexico. 2023
- 2023 **Farah, I.** “Governing the Governable: The Political Economy of Street Vending in San Francisco.” In: *Urban Affairs Association*. Nashville, Tennessee. 2023
- 2022 **Farah, I.** “The Regulation of Informal Work in Mexico City and San Francisco: Analyzing Recent Shifts in Governance Structures.” In: *Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning*. Toronto, Canada. 2023
- 2022 **Farah, I.** “Beyond Informal Politics: The Regulation of Work in Public Space.” In: *American Political Science Association*. Montreal, Canada. 2022
- 2020 **Farah, I.** “Food & Beverage Purchases by Store Type in Mexican Cities.” In: *Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning*. Online. 2020
- 2019 **Farah, I.** “Local Patterns of Co-Location in the Retail Sector: A Descriptive Study of Spatial Firm Demography.” In: *American Association of Geographers*. Washington, D.C.. 2019
- 2019 **Farah, I.** “Mexico’s Distal Effects on Food Insecurity.” In: *Western Regional Science Association*. Napa, California. 2019
- 2018 **Farah, I.** “The Death and Life of Mom and Pop: A Preliminary Analysis of Small Scale Retail in Chicago.” In: *North American Regional Science Association*. San Antonio, Texas. 2018
- 2015 **Farah, I.** “Intergenerational Educational and Occupational Mobility: A Descriptive Study of the Impoverished in Mexico.” In: *Human Development and Capabilities Association*. Washington, D.C.. 2015

AWARDS AND HONORS

- 2024 Political Economy Network Fellow, Network for a New Political Economy, UC Berkeley
- 2023 Graduate Student Fellow, Institute for the Study of Societal Issues, UC Berkeley
- 2023 Student Travel Scholarship, ACSP
- 2022 Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award, UC Berkeley
- 2022 Michael B. Teitz Fellowship, UC Berkeley
- 2021 Graduate Student Fellow, Berkeley Food Institute, UC Berkeley
- 2021 Graduate Student Fellow, D-Lab, UC Berkeley
- 2021 Tinker Field Research Grant, CLAS, UC Berkeley
- 2020 Summer Research Grant, Global Metropolitan Studies, UC Berkeley
- 2019 Outstanding Reviewer, Housing Policy Debate
- 2016 Fellowship, University of Chicago

- 2015 Award *La Flecha Al Aire* for BA thesis on education, ITAM
- 2013 Scholarship on Social Mobility Research, Centro de Estudios Espinosa Yglesias (CEEY), Mexico

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Sessions Organized

- 2025 Co-organizer: The Role of Political Intermediaries in Urban Governance in the United States. Five sessions. **Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning**, Minneapolis, Minnesota (with Ryan Devlin).
- 2024 Co-organizer: Housing and Land Regulations in the Political Economy of Urban Latin America. Five sessions. **Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning**, Seattle, Washington (with Flávia Leite).
- 2024 Co-organizer: Urban Governance of Informal Work: Perspectives Across the North-South Divide. Five sessions. **Urban Affairs Association**, New York City, New York (with Ryan Devlin).
- 2023 Organizer: Computational Approaches to Urban Planning and Management: Innovations and Challenges. Four sessions. **Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning**, Chicago, Illinois.
- 2023 Co-organizer: Informal Work and Public Space during COVID-19. Five sessions. **Urban Affairs Association**, Nashville, Tennessee (with Ryan Devlin).

Service

- 2026–27 Member, Land-Use and Environment Faculty Search Committee, DURP, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign.
- 2024–27 Ph.D. Admissions Committee, DURP, University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign.

Grant and Proposal Review

- 2021 Invited External Reviewer, Urban Challenge Grant “Climate, Justice, and Cities”, **School of Cities**, University of Toronto.

Professional Development

- 2026 Invited Speaker. “Career Strategies for International Students (Early Career).” **International Conference of Urban Affairs (ICUA)**, Chicago, Illinois.
- 2025 Invited Panelist. “From ABD to Tenure-Track.” Planners of Color Interest Group (POCIG) Roundtable. **Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning (ACSP)**, Minneapolis, Minnesota.
- 2025 Invited Panelist. “El Movimiento Sigue.” **Latinx Heritage Month**, La Casa Cultural Latina, University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign.

Manuscript Review

Berkeley Planning Journal (co-editor 2021–22); Environment and Planning B; Regional Studies, Regional Science; Food Security; Journal of Urbanism; International Journal of Public Administration; Journal of Planning Education and Research; Housing Policy Debate; Transportation Review Board; Preventive Medicine; Health and Place; Geographical Analysis.

Professional Memberships

Association of Collegiate Schools of Planning (ACSP); Urban Affairs Association (UAA); Midwestern Political Science Association (MPSA); Latin American Studies Association (LASA); American Association of Geographers (AAG).

Volunteer Work

2020, 23 Mentor, Women Leaders in STEAM (US-Mexico Leaders Network)
2018 Instructor, CompileHer, UChicago Tech Capstone
2018 Community Outreach, Scopeathon, South Side Civic
2005 Instructor and Organizer, Alfabetiza! (ADECO)

SKILLS

Computation	Python, R, STATA, PostgreSQL, Google Cloud Console
Spatial/GIS	GeoDa, QGIS, ArcGIS, PostGIS, Google Earth Engine
Tools	MS Office, Git, L ^A T _E X,
Languages	Spanish (native), English (fluent), German (A2), French (A1)